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A Sea Change

The Swadeshi Movement in Outline

It was called the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company. What was the significance of ‘Swadeshi’? To understand this, we must sketch the history of the Swadeshi movement in broad outline.

As any school textbook will tell us, the Swadeshi movement had its origins in the Partition of Bengal. What began as an idea to carve out and transfer some districts out of an admittedly straggling province shaped into a partition that had sinister political motivations. By creating a Muslim majority province of Eastern Bengal, the government hoped to undermine the growing strength of the Indian nationalist movement, spearheaded by the Hindu elite leaders of Bengal. The outcome, however, was the opposite of what the colonial masters intended.

Though the idea of partition germinated in 1903, it was formally announced by Viceroy Lord Curzon only in July 1905. Opposition to it began much before its implementation in October. This opposition transformed the nature of the nationalist struggle. C. Subramania Bharati, a child of this movement who emerged as the greatest of modern Tamil poets, aptly described it as inaugurating ‘the new path of “patriotism” that lay at the foundation of all that was good for the Indian nation’.[1]

The nationalist struggle gathered new strength in protesting against the partition, paving the way for nothing less than a demand for *Swaraj* (independence). Sumit Sarkar, the pre-eminent historian of the Swadeshi movement, captures its significance in the following terms: ‘ … with startling rapidity … the movement broke away from all traditional moorings, developed new techniques of militant action, and broadened into *a struggle for “swaraj”*.’[2]